



Toledo City Council approves Flock camera contract extension in 8-4 vote

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After weeks of debate over public safety and privacy concerns, Toledo City Council approved a one-year extension of the city's contract with Flock Group Inc. on Tuesday.

The ordinance authorizes a one-year continuation of the Toledo Police Department's use of Flock cameras. Council approved the measure 8-4.

Councilmen Erin Kramer, Theresa Gadus, Brittany Jones, and Nick Komives voted against the measure.

Other council members expressed their support for the cameras as tools for the police force.

"I am not in the mindset to take tools away from police that actually help our community," Council President Vanice Williams said. "I am all about giving police

what they need to do good work.”

Councilman George Sarantou also supported the extension.

“I think it’s a valuable tool,” he said. “Very few errors have occurred.”

Concerns about private companies handling public data deserve attention but should be addressed separately from police officer access to investigative tools, said Councilman Sam Melden.

“We need to govern that use separately,” he said.

Councilman Adam Martinez agreed with the distinction between issues of data privacy and the use of cameras as police tools.

However, Ms. Kramer said she remained concerned about the privacy implications of the technology.

“I support TPD in all that they do, but we do need to listen to the residents and look at what is happening across our country,” she said.

Ms. Kramer recalled public opposition from Monday’s public safety meeting and the multitude of emails she has received.

“It gives me pause when I hear from so many residents,” she said. “I have some real concerns.”

The council also unanimously approved an ordinance for a safety zone during the Fourth of July fireworks in Promenade Park.

The safety zone will be in effect from 6 p.m. July 4 through 6 a.m. July 5. It will also establish youth supervision requirements and enforcement provisions.

While Ms. Williams acknowledged that the safety zone ordinance is needed over the holiday, she also emphasized that it is not meant to exclude young people from public events.

“I hope that we can all understand that we are doing this so our residents can be safe when going out for events, but we are not being exclusive to our youth,” she said.

Mr. Martinez said the council’s work on the issue is far from finished.

“I want to ensure that there’s a working committee and more legislation coming,” he said.

Council also voted on two proposals for new gas stations.

A special-use permit that would have allowed gasoline and fuel sales at 1322 Bernath Pkwy. failed in an 11-1 vote.

Mr. Martinez, who voted against the permit, acknowledged the significant opposition from residents.

“There was a lot of community, I don’t want to say outrage, but they were not supportive of it,” he said.

Although the fuel sales permit was denied, council approved related legislation removing the property from an existing community unit plan and approving a zoning change.

Council did approve in a 9-3 vote a special-use permit for gasoline and fuel sales at 5305 and 5321 Monroe St. and 4700 Nantuckett Dr.

The proposal will allow a Sheetz development to move forward despite public concerns about traffic and neighborhood impact.

In other business, council unanimously approved legislation authorizing expenditures related to the city’s spent lime removal program.

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